INT. DIVE BAR - NIGHT

FADE IN

Open on a dive bar with neon lights and sticky tables. The patrons fade into the background, most of them older. Chatter and old rock music NAT, 21, sits alone nursing a beer.

Nat wears a red dress. Her makeup is smudged. A small birthday pin lies forgotten, obscured by the leather jacket she wears.

Her phone buzzes. A text from KAYLA: "so sorry!! had to see Josh. happy bday!! love u.” Eye roll.

The door swings open with yelps and shouts. ELLA, 21, steps in with 4 other girls, dressed up and glam. She wears a birthday sash, crown, and the same in as Nat.

ELLA
Omigod. Where did you guys take me??

Nat looks up at the voice. Her eyes go wide. She begins to stand up.

KATE
Relaxxxxxx Ella. Let’s get another drink.

JEN
21!21!21!

ELLA
(over the chanting)
Okay, okay!

Ella scans the bar. Nat flees to the bathroom, her stool topples over. Ella follows her track. Ella’s friends flock towards the bar.

FIONA
Drinks on me!! Vodka Cran?

ELLA
ONE SEC!!

LILA
Where are you going???

ELLA
That girl just ran in there. She looked like she was gonna barf.

Her friends begin to interject. Ella cuts them off.

ELLA (CONT'D)
No, no. I'm not even drunk. Watch me.

The girls look around seeing Ella run to the bathroom after Nat. They shrug.

INT. BAR BATHROOM - NIGHT

Nat slams the stall door behind her. She sits on the closed toilet breathing heavy. Heels clack on the tile as Ella enters the bathroom.

ELLA (OUTSIDE STALL)
HELLO? WHO'S THERE???

Nat's face goes white as she attempts to stay quiet. The heels clack closer to her stall.

ELLA (O.S.) (CONT'D)
(drunkenly) It's okayyyyy. I've been there. It's life... life.

NO RESPONSE.

BANG BANG BANG on the stall door.

ELLA (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Just let me in. I'll like hold your hair.

Nat peeks under the stall door. The heels still there. Nat breathes, preparing herself. Unlocks the door.

It swings open as Ella leans in stumbling. She stares.

ELLA (CONT'D)
Wait...Nat?

Nat tries to speak. Nothing. Ella's face goes green. Her hand flies to her mouth.

NAT
Oh no. Oh, no, no-

Ella shoves past Nat to the toilet, and vomits. LOUDLY. Nat stands, hovering. Her hand drifts toward Ella's hair, out of habit, then stops. She retracts.

NAT (CONT'D)
Um- I'm just gonna- yeah

Nat rushes out to grab a wad of toilet paper.

INT. BAR BATHROOM - LATER

Ella sits against the bathroom wall, wiping her mouth. She takes the paper towels. Looks up at Nat beaming, thrilled.

ELLA
Nat. Oh my god. NAT!!!!!

She jumps up to hug her. Nat dodges her instinctively. Ella catches herself on the wall laughing it off.

NAT
Happy birthday.

ELLA
BITCH! YOU TOO! Remember we swore we'd do our big two-ones together in elementary school???

Ella rinses her mouth at the sink, chattering to the mirror. Nat leans on the wall, arms crossed. Nat smiles, reminiscing.

NAT
I remember. Nat-ella's super sweet birthday.

ELLA
God we thought we were so smart for that. Then middle school happened. And you just...

Ella pauses, unsure of what to say. Nat jumps in.

NAT
We drifted.

Ella snorts.

ELLA
Yeah. Sure. "Drifted."

BEAT.

ELLA (CONT'D)
Honestly, I'm not mad anymore. I worked it out in therapy

NAT
(a nervous laugh)
Therapy?

ELLA
Eighth grade. The lunch table. That group chat.

NAT
We were kids, Ella.

ELLA
We were. Kids who wrote “Ella smells like wet dog and desperation. Nobody wants you here” on my locker door.

NAT
I don't remember that.

Ella studies her. Pitiful, not mad. And it’s almost worse.

ELLA
You wrote it, Nat.

NAT
No. We just grew apart. That’s all.

ELLA
(softly)
Okay.

Ella pulls the door open. The party noise floods in. She turns back.

ELLA (CONT’D)
Come sit with us. It's your birthday too.

NAT
My friend's coming back.

Ella sees the empty bar stool through the doorway. She nods.

ELLA
Happy birthday, Nat.

She leaves. The door swings shut behind her. Nat is alone. She turns to the mirror. Her hands grip the sink. She’s sad, and she is furious about it. She opens her jacket to the "21" button. She fiddles with it, but she can't unpin it. Through the wall, muffled and joyful, Ella’s friends start again:

GIRLFRIENDS (O.S.)
Twenty-one! Twenty-one! Twenty-one!

Nat flinches.